



Photographs by RANJAN RAHI

**RESCUED TRIBAL GIRLS UNDERGO PHYSICAL TRAINING FOR EMPLOYMENT AS SECURITY GUARDS (ABOVE); PATNAIK WITH SOME OF THE TRAINED GIRLS (BELOW)**

**SUSHMA KUMARI 18**

Kumari has come a long way since her Mumbai days in 2006 when she was regularly beaten up and left hungry as a house maid. Now she is employed as a security guard in Delhi.

**BEENA KUJUR 18**

Kujur, who has received training in housekeeping and hospitality after being rescued, has been handed over the charge of a VVIP guesthouse at Khelgaon, Hotwar Ranchi.



The ATSEC has also tied up with the state Criminal Investigation Department and the Jharkhand Education Project, and meaningfully rehabilitated 70-odd girls. In fact, new partners like steel behemoth Arcelor Mittal have sponsored a training course for security guards. The project, however, underlines the vulnerability of Jharkhand girls to human trafficking. Rough estimates by NGOs put the number of such girls at 2.5 lakh and more than half are said to be minors. The ugly face of trafficking is clearly visible at Kishori Niketan, a shelter home run by BKS at Bijupada, 40 kms from Ranchi. Medical tests confirm physical and sexual abuse. One of the inmates, Sheela was six-month pregnant when she was rescued. She has given birth to a baby girl. Such stories are not very uncommon, with many saying they are afraid to go home as their parents will again sell them off. There are also a few like 13-year-old Jambi Soy, who do not have any idea about where her parents are. She was packed off to Delhi when she was "very young".

All are victims of trafficking by over 1,000 illegal placement agencies operating from the national capital. These unscrupulous operatives send scouts across Jharkhand to arrange for young girls. They are promised a better life, and the agents back their offers with a small payment to their parents or to a crooked relative or neighbour. "Girls who manage to escape from their employers' homes often reach nowhere and become vulnerable to sexual abuse," says Mishra.

Even the Maoists prey on vulnerable families by forcefully recruiting male children as foot soldiers and abusing young girls. Besides, a less than ordinary law and order and few employment avenues leave the vulnerable people grappling for survival. Today, a Jambi studying at Kishori Niketan, or a Sushma packing her bags for Delhi represent a new hope for the exploited and a new avenue of employment for thousands of vulnerable girls in Jharkhand's volatile tribal belts. ■